Harvard Health Systems Innovation Lab
2026 Hackathon Guide for Judges

Thank you for joining us as a judge, and welcome to the 7th annual Health Systems Innovation Hackathon! The Health System Innovation Lab (HSIL) organizes a yearly Hackathon in collaboration with our partners around the world. The Hackathon is a transformative event with a clear mission: to empower innovators to develop innovative solutions that improve health systems. This dynamic and collaborative event brings together students, young professionals and experts from diverse fields to address critical health system challenges through innovation. By bringing together professionals from different backgrounds, it fosters cross-disciplinary collaboration and unconventional thinking to develop innovative solutions. Teams are supported to develop groundbreaking and practical solutions that can challenge the status quo and transform healthcare, bridging the gap between theory and practice. Teams will not only collaborate intensively during the event but hopefully also establish relationships and networks that extend beyond its duration.
In summary, the HSIL Hackathon is a powerful platform for innovation and collaboration, dedicated to improving healthcare systems around the world.

The 2026 Hackathon

This year's Hackathon will take place on **Friday 10th and Saturday 11th April 2025** and the theme is: **'Building High-Value Health Systems: Leveraging Artificial Intelligence'**.

How is the Hackathon organized?

The Hackathon is organized as a **two-day in person event** in several Hubs across the world, including: North America, Central and South America, Europe, the UK, Asia and Africa. Over the two-day hackathon, teams will identify a health system challenge they want to tackle and develop an innovative solution to it. Teams will have access to mentors who have healthcare expertise and health innovation experience. They will advise the teams, challenge their assumptions, and provide feedback on their pitch.

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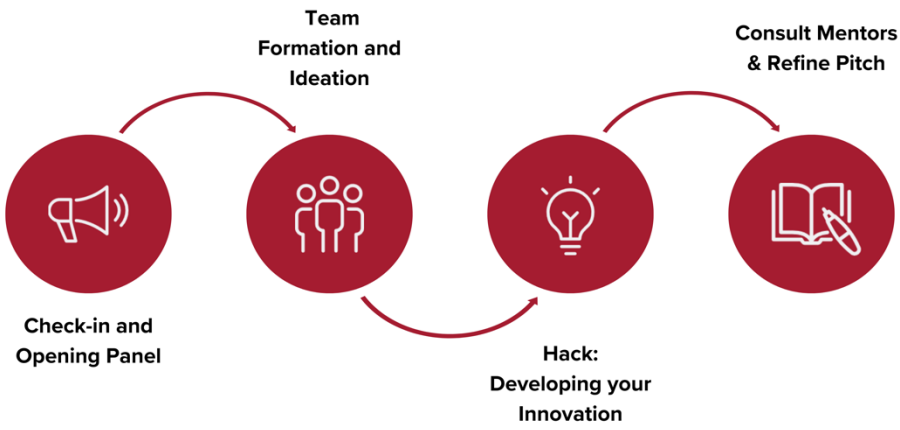
Teams will get ready to present their solution in front of a local judging panel by the end of the two days. Judges from each Hub will **select three winning teams.**

What will happen during the Hackathon?



What to expect for the pitch?

At the end of the Hackathon, teams are expected to deliver a 3-minute presentation, or 'pitch', to present their idea and convince the judges of its value.

Considering most Hackathon pitches last 3 minutes, here's a rule of thumb for maximizing impact within that tight timeframe that we shared with participants.

- **Introduction (10 seconds):** Briefly introduce yourself and your team in a memorable way. Since people recall more easily how things start and finish, ensure your introduction makes a lasting impression as the judges deliberate.
- **Problem statement (20 seconds):** Clearly describe the problem you are addressing. Whose lives can be improved by your solution, and what tangible impact will it have?
- **Product (1 minute):** Explain the technical aspects of your idea. Provide enough detail to demonstrate your technical expertise and decision-making process, without overwhelming your audience with excessive information.
- **Demo (1 minute):** Support your product presentation with a live demo (if possible) or use visualization tools to mock up the design, functionality, and key features

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- **Wrap-up (30 seconds):** Summarize the main points of your pitch and end with a strong closing statement.

How will teams participating in the Hackathon be judged?

All teams will pitch their innovation in front of local judges on the **2nd day of the Hackathon**. Each Hub will select local judges to take part in the **judging panel** on **April 11th** (the exact time will depend on the local schedule of each Hub). The judging panel will consist of three to five judges collectively bringing in clinical, technical, and business expertise.

The judging panel will identify the best digital health solutions with a high potential for transforming healthcare systems and improving care around the world. Judging criteria can be found in the table below.

What happens after the Hackathon? The HSIL Venture Incubation Program

The top team (first place) from each Hub will present their innovation to a Global Judging panel online in the weeks following the Hackathon. The winners from the second round of judging will participate in a Venture Incubation program hosted by the Harvard Health Systems Innovation Lab and its collaborators. This program will be held virtually shortly after the Hackathon.

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Judging rubric for the Health Systems Innovation Hackathon

Criterion	Considerations	Score
1. Challenge	- Is a clear need articulated? - Does the team demonstrate understanding of the root causes of the problem? - Is this a significant problem to address in terms of size, disease burden, consequences or perception? - Does the team provide a convincing rationale as to why this needs to be addressed urgently?	/5
2. Technology & Innovation	- Offers new technology solution (better / faster / cheaper) - Provides convincing rationale for why this unique approach has the potential to work (if it doesn't exist already in any other form) - If the solution is focused on low resource settings, it addresses relevant technical issues (e.g., low-cost components, intermittent power supply, limited internet) - Does the team clearly describe what the innovation is, its components and how it will address the challenge? - Does the innovation possess transformative potential to improve outcomes at the health systems level? - Does the team consider design and user experience in its innovation?	/5
3. Implementation	- Beyond need, is there a demand for this solution? - Does the team address obstacles to implementation and outlines a plan to overcome them? (e.g., Logistics, supply chain, overstretched implementing organizations, cultural appropriateness, etc.) - Does the team outline a plan to develop the innovation and introduce it into the health system? - Is there a sustainable business model and value proposition? - Are critical stakeholders, the health system and the context adequately considered as part of the implementation strategy?	/5

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4. Team	- Is the team equipped with the right skill mix and attitude to implement the proposed innovation?	/5
5. Pitch	- Does the team demonstrate the prototype or solution? - Does the team clearly articulate the challenge it is addressing and how their innovation is addressing it? - Does the team document next steps clearly – i.e. how they plan on working in the field to test their solution and how to continually incorporate end user feedback? - Are visual aids (presentation design and use of diagrams and figures) used effectively?	/5
6. Question & Answer	- Is the team able to successfully defend their position and confidently respond to specific questions from the judges?	/5
7. Total		**/30**

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